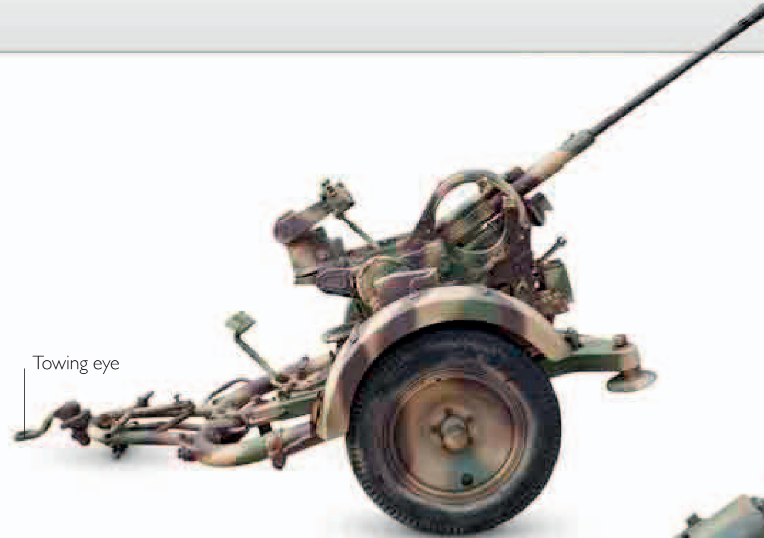
ANTIAIRCRAFT GUNS

Specialized antiaircraft guns were developed as soon as aircraft became a perceived threat at the beginning of World War I. By the outset of World War II, aircraft had become a major threat to ground forces, and heavy guns were designed to fire projectiles at a high altitude for high-flying aircraft, while light-caliber guns fired rapidly at low-flying aircraft. The target height was measured by optical instruments on the ground. Antiaircraft guns fired shells with fuses timed to explode when they reached target height. Aircraft were not usually brought down by direct hits, but by shrapnel from these bursting shells, which came to be known as "flak."



FULL VIEW

▼ 2CM FLAK 38 2CM ANTIAIRCRAFT GUN

Date	1943
Origin	Germany
Length	13¼ft (4.08m)
Caliber	20mm
Range	1½ miles (2.2km)

The German term for antiaircraft guns, Flak (*Flugzeugabwehrkanone*), gave its name to the bursting shells of antiaircraft guns in general. The German arms manufacturer Rheinmetall started an adaptation of the naval 2cm Antiaircraft (AA) gun for army use, producing the Flak 30 and later, the Flak 38.